

Aphrodite's Harvest

Blog Content - SEO Implementation

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What Makes Honey Raw? A Guide to Unprocessed South Australian Honey

If you have ever stood in a supermarket aisle wondering what 'raw honey' actually means, you are not alone. With so many labels claiming to be natural, pure, or organic, it can be hard to know what you are actually buying. This guide explains exactly what raw honey South Australia producers like Aphrodite's Harvest offer - and why it matters for your health, your taste buds, and the environment.

What Is Raw Honey?

Raw honey is honey that has not been heated, pasteurised, or heavily filtered after it leaves the hive. It is extracted, lightly strained to remove wax and debris, and then bottled - nothing more.

Most commercial honey sold in supermarkets is processed at high temperatures to improve shelf appearance and prevent crystallisation. This process, while convenient, destroys many of the naturally occurring enzymes, antioxidants, and pollen that give honey its nutritional value.

Raw honey retains everything the bees put into it - enzymes, pollen, propolis traces, and naturally occurring antioxidants. Processed honey is essentially sugar syrup with a honey flavour.

How Raw Honey Is Produced in South Australia

South Australia's diverse flora - from the Adelaide Hills to the Fleurieu Peninsula - gives local honey a flavour profile you simply cannot replicate anywhere else in the world. At Aphrodite's Harvest, our bees forage across native and cultivated plants, producing honey with rich, complex flavour notes that change seasonally.

Our raw honey production process is straightforward by design:

- Frames are extracted using a cold-extraction process - no heat applied
- Honey passes through a coarse filter to remove wax and hive debris
- It is rested in settling tanks to allow air bubbles to rise naturally
- Bottled at ambient temperature and sealed immediately

The result is honey that looks, smells, and tastes exactly as nature intended.

Why Does Raw Honey Crystallise?

If you have ever opened a jar of honey to find it thick and grainy, congratulations - you have real raw honey. Crystallisation is a completely natural process and is actually a sign of quality. Glucose in the honey naturally precipitates out of solution over time.

How to re-liquefy crystallised honey

Simply place the sealed jar in a bowl of warm water (no hotter than 40°C) and stir occasionally. Never microwave honey - the heat destroys the very enzymes that make raw honey worth buying.

Raw Honey vs Organic Honey - What Is the Difference?

These two terms are often confused. Organic honey Australia producers must meet strict certification standards around pesticide use and hive management. Raw simply refers to the processing method. Honey can be raw but not organic, organic but not raw, both, or neither.

At Aphrodite's Harvest, our honey is produced using ethical beekeeping practices aligned with organic principles, even where formal certification is not sought - because certification costs should not be a barrier to doing things the right way.

How to Use Raw Honey

- Stir into warm (not hot) herbal tea to preserve the enzymes
- Drizzle over Greek yoghurt or granola for a natural sweetener
- Use as a glaze for roasted vegetables or grilled chicken
- Apply directly to minor skin irritations or dry patches
- Add to salad dressings in place of sugar

One important tip: never give raw honey to children under 12 months. While safe for adults, raw honey can contain Clostridium botulinum spores that infants cannot yet safely process.

Ready to Try Real Raw Honey from South Australia?

Aphrodite's Harvest produces small-batch raw honey from our South Australian apiary, harvested ethically and bottled with care. Whether you are new to raw honey or a long-time fan, you will taste the difference from your very first spoonful.

Browse our current honey range in the Shop, or visit our LearnAboutBees page to discover more about how we care for our hives and the environment around them.

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Varroa Mite in Australia: What Every Beekeeper Needs to Know in 2026

The arrival of Varroa destructor in Australia has changed beekeeping permanently. After decades of being Varroa-free - an advantage Australian beekeepers held over the rest of the world - the pest was detected in New South Wales in 2022 and has since spread significantly. If you keep bees in Australia, understanding Varroa mite prevention is no longer optional. It is essential.

What Is Varroa Destructor?

Varroa destructor is a parasitic mite that attaches to honey bees and their brood, feeding on the fat bodies of developing and adult bees. Left unmanaged, a Varroa infestation will collapse a hive within one to three years. The mite also acts as a vector for multiple bee viruses, including Deformed Wing Virus, which causes bees to emerge with crumpled, non-functional wings.

A healthy colony can tolerate low levels of Varroa, but populations grow exponentially. By the time you see visible symptoms in your bees, the infestation is often already severe.

The Situation in Australia in 2026

Varroa mite prevention Australia beekeepers need to practise has evolved rapidly since the initial detection. As of 2026, Varroa is established in parts of New South Wales and is subject to ongoing biosecurity management across multiple states. South Australian beekeepers remain on high alert, with strict movement controls and surveillance programs in place.

For South Australian beekeepers, the current priority is:

- Regular hive monitoring to detect early arrival
- Maintaining accurate hive records for traceability
- Reporting any unusual bee mortality or symptoms immediately
- Understanding treatment options so you are ready to act quickly

How to Monitor Your Hives for Varroa

Early detection is everything. Two methods are widely recommended for Australian beekeepers:

1. Alcohol wash (most accurate)

Take a sample of approximately 300 bees from the brood nest area. Place them in a jar with isopropyl alcohol, shake for 60 seconds, then strain through a mesh. Count the mites. A result of more than 2 mites per 100 bees (2% infestation rate) is the threshold for treatment action in most guidelines.

2. Sugar roll (bee-friendly alternative)

The same process using icing sugar instead of alcohol. The bees can be returned to the hive after counting. Slightly less accurate than alcohol wash, but suitable for beekeepers who prefer not to sacrifice a sample.

Check every hive at least once per month during the active season. Keep records of your counts - this is critical for demonstrating biosecurity compliance and for tracking trends over time.

Treatment Options for Varroa

If Varroa is detected, several registered treatment options are available in Australia. Always check the current APVMA registration for treatments in your state, as approvals and withholding periods change:

- Oxalic acid (OA) - highly effective on mites in broodless periods; approved for use in Australia
- Formic acid (MAQS/Formic Pro) - effective against mites under capped brood; temperature-dependent
- Thymol-based treatments (Apiguard) - effective in warmer conditions; natural origin
- Synthetic miticides (Apivar) - highly effective but must be rotated to prevent resistance

Resistance management is critical. Rotating between treatment modes of action prevents Varroa from developing immunity to any single product. Never rely on one treatment type exclusively.

What South Australian Beekeepers Should Do Right Now

Even if Varroa has not been detected in your area, preparation is the responsible approach. At Aphrodite's Harvest, we follow a biosecurity-first approach to hive management. Here is what we recommend:

- Register your hives with the SA Apiarist Registration if you have not already
- Attend a Varroa identification workshop - several are available online through state agriculture departments
- Purchase an alcohol wash kit and practise the technique before you need it
- Keep detailed hive inspection records with dates, colony strength, and any anomalies
- Know your local biosecurity officer's contact details and report any concerns immediately

Learn More with Aphrodite's Harvest

Staying informed is the best defence Australian beekeepers have. Our Courses and LearnAboutBees pages offer practical, up-to-date guidance on hive management, biosecurity, and sustainable beekeeping in South Australia.

Have questions about Varroa or your hives? Browse our Support options or get in touch directly - we are here to help South Australian beekeepers thrive through whatever challenges lie ahead.

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